

THE TARGET Majithia speaks on the raids at his house, Jun. 25

▶ PUNJAB

MANN CHASES A FIX ON MAJITHIA

The war on drugs sees a dramatic political twist, as push comes to shove for 'tainted' SAD man

Mann as well as the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in the state and there is criticism that this is payback.

The case is not new. Majithia was booked in 2021 under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act by the then Congress government led by Charanjit Channi based on an ED report going back to 2018. The case has had little legs, but now the VB is claiming progress in a fresh FIR.

The manner of his arrest—pre-dawn raids started with a dozen sleuths descending on his farmhouse—has not gone down well with the SAD leadership. Party president and Majithia's brother-in-law Sukhbir Singh Badal declared it a "cowardly act of vendetta". Regular Mann baiters like ex-CM Channi, BJP state unit chief Sunil Jakhar and others have also criticised the regime's heavy-handed handling of the arrest. But they haven't been too convincing since many of these leaders have been pointing fingers at Majithia's 'drugs connection' for ages (indeed, he first went to jail in 2022 when Channi was the CM). The case is not all that clear-cut either—some of those who made drugs allegations, including AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, had to issue public apologies later after the SAD leader took them to court.

Takeaways

- **SAD leaders up in arms over arrest of Majithia. Oppn flays heavy-handed approach**
- **AAP framing it as turning point in war on drugs mafia-gangster nexus**

But Majithia's arrest is not just about the SAD versus AAP. It comes in the backdrop of CM Mann's renewed campaign against Punjab's entrenched drugs-and-gangsters ecosystem. Since March 1 this year, the AAP government has taken a leaf out of Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath's "bulldozer model"—razing illegal constructions of alleged traffickers and ganglords. From Moga to Malerkotla, over a hundred such structures have been targeted across Punjab in recent weeks.

BIG FISH, BIG TASK

Majithia's arrest, then, is being framed by the Mann government as a turning point—an effort at going after the "big fish". In press briefings, AAP leaders have been positioning it as a show of political will to tackle powerful figures long involved in the drug trafficking business and considered untouchable. But this will be a test of intent and capacity. The sleuths have recorded the statements of former Akali Dal MLA, Amarpal Singh Bonny Ajnala, and former long term Majithia aide Talbir Singh Gill. Ajnala is now with the BJP, while Gill moved to AAP in 2024. Vigilance sleuths have also recorded the statements of former ED deputy director Niranjan Singh and controversial ex-DGP Siddharth Chattopadhyaya, who had both led earlier investigations against Majithia.

Punjab has seen drug crackdowns before—often headline-grabbing, but rarely sustained. Whether this latest chapter delivers justice or merely adds to the archive of performative politics depends on Mann's resolve. The results could alter the political future of both AAP and the SAD in Punjab. ■